# Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107) which allows use for commentary, criticism, news reporting, research, teaching or scholarship without requiring permission from the rights holder.

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (315) 859-4071.

# John Fedchock

*Trombonist and band leader John Fedchock was born in Cleveland, Ohio on September 18, 1957. He served as Musical Director of the Woody Herman band after graduation from the Eastman School of Music, and formed the John Fedchock New York Big Band in 1992. John is a prolific composer and maintains an active presence in the jazz education scene.*

*John was interviewed in Clinton, New York on May 28, 2015, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.*

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and this is the Hamilton College Fillius Jazz Archive. I have John Fedchock with me today. And thanks for coming.

JF: Sure. Glad I could make it.

MR: Yeah. I think, reading about you, to me you're the very definition of a working musician.

JF: I try to.

MR: Can you describe — well it's Thursday, just past the middle of the week. What is a typical week like for you as a working musician?

JF: There really is no typical week. The typical is there's no typical. It really depends on the time of year, it could be, you know I could be traveling doing something at a school, I could be overseas, I could be home writing, I could be working in Manhattan, I could be just practicing and honing my craft I guess you could say. So there really is no typical Thursday.

MR: And do you like it that way?

JF: I do, I do. When I first moved to New York I did anything and everything, as one would want to do when you move to a new city, including Broadway and commercial work, and a lot of I guess you could say non-creative type of things, where they just need someone to come in and play trombone or someone to write a certain number of measures or whatever. But through my past experiences touring with Woody Herman and other people, I just really worked toward that my entire life. And after getting off the road, to me it would seem silly to just let it go and have that be part of the past — all that stuff I have accomplished — and just start banging it out like assembly line kind of music. Obviously it's not all like that in the commercial world, but I kind of wanted to keep like a little of that creative freedom going.

MR: By banging it out do you mean like getting a pit band job for "The Lion King" and just doing that until —

JF: Yeah. Basically I mean I have one friend who's been playing "The Lion King" since it opened in 1998. You know? And that can get to your psyche. When I first moved to New

York, within the first few weeks I was doing a gig and sitting next to someone who had been playing "Cats" for years. For the entire run. And I said, "I just moved to town." And he said, "oh you play really great." I said, "yeah I just moved to town and if you ever need a sub at your show —." And he goes, "you know I'd love to have you in but I would hate for Broadway to do to you what it did to me." And that put a little jar into me at the moment. It was like okay, well there's something to this you know, just kind of going like a factory worker, showing up. And there's been many accounts of people that go to those types of positions. And if you're not careful and do other things or force yourself to practice other things, you get to the point where you can play the show great but that's all you can play. And you know it gets to that point where you just get so comfortable with those notes in that same order every night, many times a week. That was frightening. Plus I love to improvise, I love to play creative music, I love to write. So I did play Broadway shows for a while but then when other things in my career started taking off I kind of let that go.

MR: That's a great story. I remember — I got to sit in just to observe in the pit band of "Cats" when it came to Utica. And the guys would play their parts, then they'd pick up a book —

JF: Sure.

MR: And I had never really witnessed that part of it before. It was a bit of an eye-opener.

JF: Yeah. When you're playing a show, when you go to sub on a show, you first have to go down into the pit and sit through a show watching the regular person play the show and watch the music go by and see what they're doing and they give you little instructions here and there. And one of the first shows I went to watch was something that had been running for a long time and no one even had music on the stand, they had magazines and stuff. So you know they gave me the music and everybody's got magazines on their music stands. They're reading magazines actually while they're playing. So you get to the point where you're that separated from the music.

MR: Yeah. Okay. Well when you were in eighth grade, I'm just going to pick eighth grade —

JF: Okay.

MR: Because it's an interesting time for a young man. Did you have these aspirations then?

JF: I loved music and I loved the trombone and I loved just the social aspect of the band, but I also loved the fact that it was something that I did pretty well and I felt like it was something that would get me out of my shell a little bit. And I started messing around with writing a little bit. I had — my uncle sent me a double album set of Tommy Dorsey's big band. He said if you play trombone you should know who Tommy Dorsey is. So I listened to that, and tried to transcribe one of the charts, and this was in eighth grade. You know I didn't really know what I was doing. And I'm trying to transcribe it

off an LP. So you can imagine what it did to the record. But that was a learning experience. And then — so it kind of started around that time believe it or not, like seventh or eighth grade where I was thinking this is a lot of fun, I wish I could do this all the time. I didn't know you could actually do it, but I was hoping that there was some way I could continue playing that kind of music.

MR: Did it ever occur to you or your parents or your teachers that there was another route besides going to music school, or was that sort of understood if you wanted to pursue this.

JF: Well my first trombone teacher I started with in ninth grade, and aside from about a year and a half he took me all the way through the end of my high school days, was a kind of a freelance guy in Cleveland, Ohio, who played with the big bands. He wasn't a classical player by any means, but he was one of the more I guess you could say working musicians in the Cleveland area. And even on our lessons we never really practiced diehard classical repertoire. We did technical things, but then we would always end up playing like pop duets and things like that. So I wasn't really exposed to that kind of element. But when I really got interested in jazz and in music, that's when I decided I wanted to continue, jazz is what got me excited about it, but at the same time I think it was kind of implied in my family that I was going to college. So I said I'd like to major in music. And really, to be honest, I didn't think I was strong enough to be a performer at the time so I majored in music education. And then about halfway through my studies at Ohio State University in my undergrad years they started a jazz degree. And so I started taking all the jazz classes too. So I did two degrees, jazz and music ed. And then with the hopes of getting good enough to get into a high powered grad school, Eastman in particular, because when I was in high school Woody Herman's band came to my school and did a concert and a clinic and I was super stoked because it was like obviously a great band. And they were playing great classic literature but they were also playing very modern things, and the band was full of guys in their twenties. And I thought wow, this is something that's not just nostalgia and from old records. And I noticed Woody was getting a lot of trombone players from Eastman. So I thought well there's got to be something there to get me to the next step. So that was kind of my short term goal, just to get good enough to get into Eastman and then from Eastman kind of maybe find a way to get on Woody's band.

MR: That was good planning on your part.

JF: It was pretty lucky calculations yeah.

MR: I'm jealous because you lived — you did one of my dreams. I always wanted to be like in a big band, one of the name — and you became Music Director. What responsibilities did that entail for that band?

JF: Well at the time I took over for that. I wrote all the new charts, with a couple of exceptions of guys trying stuff on the band. But I wrote all the charts, and anything new I would rehearse the band. Woody would not be around. We would work things up without him around and then he would ask me if it was good enough to call on the gig. So he would hear it for the first time on the bandstand.

MR: Oh really.

JF: Yeah. And then when we started recording I would run the recording sessions and help mix the albums and all that stuff. So it was all on me. Woody was really trusting with his musical directors, and his sidemen for that matter. He never really told anybody how to play. He just trusted if you were good enough to be on his band you knew what to do.

MR: Talk about postgraduate education, huh?

JF: Yeah.

MR: Did you ever have to be a disciplinarian?

JF: No. Not really. I think in one rehearsal, because we always had to rehearse either after the gig or on a day off or something. And I remember one rehearsal prior to one of our albums where it was getting kind of late and guys were getting a little tired and cranky and I kind of clamped down for just a moment. But really not much.

MR: Those — is it safe to say that those stories about being on the band bus for many, many hours and all the bad habits that would come of it were pretty much in the past?

JF: Yeah. That really, we didn't feel the effects of it. When I joined the band it was kind of the band to make fun of. Because before I got on the band there were — I joined the band in 1980. So in the 70s there were a lot of drugs and obviously Woody's early bands had some very hard drugs. But when I joined the band it was a bunch of guys like myself in our early twenties. It just so happened five of us joined on the same day, which is almost half the band, or a third of the band, and none of us did any of that stuff. And, you know, we're taking vitamins, and it was like completely opposite. I don't know if you recall, but in the 80s there was a big health surge where people were taking supplements and vitamins and trying to exercise and things. That was probably a result of everybody's parents having heart attacks and things, ten years before that. But yeah, we were pretty healthy. I mean we got in trouble as guys in their twenties do, but there was not that influence on the band anymore.

MR: So can I imagine you on the band bus with a score pad in front of you, could you write?

JF: No I never really wrote on the bus while it was moving. I would do it in the hotel rooms. I'd do it when he had a break or a day off. I carried a little keyboard about this big, battery powered, that I had in my suitcase, which I still have. And I wrote with, up until about three or four years ago, until I finally broke down and learned some computer

programs. But that was my comfort — it sounded really bad but I knew if I could get a chord to sound really good on that thing, it would sound amazing with the band.

MR: Good point.

JF: And the keys were small so I could fit the entire voicing within my two hands. I wouldn't have a reach or hold the pedal down or anything, I could just do that and hear all the voices, which was really helpful for me.

MR: I like that kind of story, that sort of low-tech, all you need is that little tool and it helps you to be creative.

JF: Yeah.

MR: Does using Sibelius or Finale or whatever, do you think it's changed the sound of what you write?

JF: It did for a short time I think. I mean it probably would be inaudible to most people. But it affected the way I write and the thought process. I had to find a way around — strangely enough — I had to find my way around the technology to get to the music. I mean in the past writing with pencil and paper I have an idea and I could scribble on the page and just keep the pages turning. So I'd have a feeling of forward momentum, even if I didn't have the exacts, I could just scribble something, turn the page and I could look back at it and just keep the pencil going and make little notes as I'm going so I have this feeling of this overall, that you can't get with a computer really. You can't do that. Because you have to take time and enter stuff, and there's no real way to scribble, as of yet. I know they're working on new stuff where you can do that. But trying to find a way around that. Fortunately years and years and years of writing with pencil and paper I kind of figured out a technique for writing that I use so I had to find a way to have that translate to the electronic era. And it's still something that I'm still working on. But I have a new album coming out in August and I think half of the music was written into a computer — directly into the computer. My thought was, when I was learning the program, was let's just do this cold turkey. And I wrote a chart with no keyboard, nothing. I went on the road for three weeks, I had a tour in Japan. And I had several days off. And I said okay I'm just going to learn this and try to write something. And I wrote it and it came out fine, but it's not anything I'd put on an album or anything but it came out fine. But now I have kind of a way to approach it where I don't feel stilted.

MR: You know I've had occasions where I do some writing like that, and you almost accidentally drag a note down or something in the third trombone part or something, and it lands on this thing and you play it back and you go — oh I like that.

JF: Oh it gives you something, yeah.

MR: But you almost feel like you're cheating because you don't really know what it was.

JF: Yeah. The advantages I find are if you want to hear something right away you can hear it. I used to write everything with pencil and paper and then I would enter it into a sequencer that had really good sounds, so it would sound like the band, but it would take time. Now I can write two or three measures if I wanted to listen to the voicing or something I'd just go back and kind of listen to it in context a little better. Because I'm a horrible piano player.

MR: For original compositions for big band, do you need to have the whole song first? Like lead sheet, melody and chords?

JF: If I'm writing for the big band I guess it depends on the type of tune it is, but in a general sense yes. I need to have an idea of how it starts and how it ends as far as the initial themes. You know, how I develop them over the course of the arrangement, that remains to be seen what's going to happen. But the general sense, the ebb and flow of the melody and the form of the tune, I kind of have got to have that to start with. Actually I recently just started writing some things that I just start writing and see where it goes, but because I don't have that visual of the paper and pencil where I can like lay out four or five score pages and actually kind of visualize it, it's hard to do page by page. So I'm still trying to work on it and I'm getting over that hurdle.

MR: How do you deal with the idea that introduction, melody, you have a bridge, maybe go back — it's almost like A-A-B-A, whatever — and you do that much and you get to this point and then what? Do you have things in mind where you can go other than just okay tenor solo?

JF: Yeah. I usually try to do something where it's not predictable kind of in 8-bar phrases or whatever. And usually I kind of plan in my head before I start writing. And once I have the themes and the general sense of what the tune is — I kind of map it out in my head before I go to paper or to the computer, just as to what the general idea is and what's going to happen next. Like after the tune itself is over is there going to be some type of sendoff into a solo or is it going to be an ensemble section that develops some of the themes, or is there going to be just some kind of brief interlude, am I going to stretch the form, am I going to keep it squared off. You know, all those types of things. And usually because I've written so many other things in my life, always when I get to that point and I think of something it's usually I'm trying to think of something I haven't done before. Now obviously you're going to do similar things, people have their way of writing. But I always try to approach it in a way that lets — if it's this kind of tune or I've written this kind of tune before and when it gets to this part of this kind of tune I don't want to do what I did on this or this. So I try to find new ways to do it, either by — well on the new album I have a blues. It's a 12-bar blues. And after the tune there is a little bit of a sendoff into a solo, but rather — and then staying within the standard form of the blues I

alter one of the phrases to be extra long. So it's just enough to kind of throw you off. You're expecting the four chord to come in bar five but it comes in bar six. Or something like that.

MR: From a logistical standpoint, keeping a big band together must be a chore.

JF: It is because, especially in a city like New York, there are very few venues that are large enough, that have a large enough stage to put a big band on. And then you get to the point, especially as my band had some notoriety, that you kind of don't want to undersell yourself and put yourself in a venue that might be thought of as maybe a lesser venue. Because most of those don't pay. And I've gotten to the point where my band actually gets paid to play, and I don't feel right about asking my guys to play for free number one, and number two I don't want to pay for it completely out of my pocket. So there are certain performance venues that are there but I avoid them because I know there's no way to compensate my guys for what they're worth.

MR: Well then there must have been a point early on where you were — the band was playing for nothing?

JF: It was never nothing. We played a club, when I first moved to town we played a club called Visiones, which is no longer there, it was just around the corner from the Blue Note. And I think the guys made 25 bucks a night or something like that, 20, 25 bucks a night. But to be honest, even in a really, one of the better clubs in town, they can't afford to guarantee a lot of money. So I mean even a hundred dollars a guy, I mean that's $1600. For a club to hope they're going to sell that many tickets is a tough sell. So some of those places they give you less but give you part of the door so you hope that you're going to bring in enough people to make it worth your while, or you tell the guys, "here's the deal, we're guaranteed this, I can for sure give you 60 bucks, but it might be 150, you know, depending on who comes. So tell everybody you know." And that's an interesting thing too because when the band first started we were all kids, 20s and 30s, and that's the time when you're getting out and having fun and hanging out late and guys are meeting girls, girls are meeting guys, and everybody's friends are coming to hang out and staying up late, nobody's got any morning obligations, nobody's got kids. So everybody in the band was having three, four, five friends come every time we played. Now it's like, "well my wife has to stay home with the kid," or, someone's got to walk the dog, or all this stuff. So it's a different type of thing now.

MR: That made me think of — Bill Holman told me that he was complaining to Woody Herman about a tempo that Woody chose for one of his charts and Woody said to him, "well you know what I say to people who tell me that? I say 'make your own band.'" So you have to pay a price to hear your tunes.

JF: That's right.

MR: That's cool. So the studio work that you did, including the pit band, that's mostly like word of mouth? You get into New York and you start subbing and do a good job hopefully and then —

JF: Yeah. That's basically — it's word of —. I was fortunate. When I moved to New York I had done two albums with Woody. They were both Grammy nominated. I was soloing on it but I wrote most of the music. So I came into town and several people knew who I was, which helped me get past a couple of those early painful stages a lot of people moving to a town fresh out of nowhere have to deal with. So I was subbing on shows within a month of being in New York, and that got me in with the right group of people and I had people recommending — within a year I was recommended to a tour with Gerry Mulligan. I met a whole bunch of people there. And things like that happened because I was with Woody. And also because I was with Woody for so long. I was touring with him for seven years. During that time a lot of guys came and went, many moving to New York. So I had a whole network of folks I could draw on, at least, whether they could get me work or not they could recommend who to talk to or whatever. But once I got kind of doing the Broadway stuff, then the contractors kind of got wind of who I was because they have to pay everybody and they see your name coming up on paychecks. Okay and then they ask about — oh is this the guy. Okay. And then all of a sudden you're starting to get called for commercial dates or movie dates or things like that. And there was one contractor who just recently passed away who had a little brass quintet (sextet? octet?) that he would rehearse every Wednesday just so he could play. And that was his way of getting to know people. And I played one rehearsal with him and the next thing I know I'm doing a movie date for him. So it's really who you meet and who hears you and of course you have to play well but you also have to do all the other things that most music students don't think about is that you've got to show up on time, you've got to have decent hygiene, you have to dress right, you have to be cordial and know how to talk to people and all those things you don't study in music school. How to make a first impression basically. And so that came a little sooner than it would with a lot of people.

MR: It's interesting you said that because I wrote down this question I wanted to ask you: what don't jazz students learn in school?

JF: People skills basically.

MR: People skills.

JF: You know when I go to schools I say, "look around this room. Someone in this room is going to get you a really good gig one day. So it would behoove you all to be very nice to everybody." Because it may be someone who's playing third trombone in the third jazz band, and you're looking down at him like this guy's nothing. And then later on he's not playing anymore but he owns a jazz club because he loves jazz. Or he's an exec on a

record label or something. So all these things come back. And I try to tell students not only the people in this music school, but try to interact with people outside of the music building. Because when you're talking to like record executives or advertising people when you're playing a jingle for somebody, you know, they don't speak the language, the musical language. I mean we get so used to talking to other musicians because it's comfortable. We can talk about the same kinds of things. But sometimes you have to deal with people that are not musicians and if you can endear yourself to them that's like gold in the music industry. Executives, and there are some contractors in New York that don't play, that are not musicians. They wish they could be musicians a lot of them. But they're not really players. So just having a feeling of being able to interact with people comfortably. Because the last thing you want to do is make someone uncomfortable. If you're making them uncomfortable they're not going to want to have you around so you're not going to get hired. So that's a lot of what the music business is, because it's assumed everybody plays well. It's just assumed. If you're in New York as a professional musician, you've got to be a good player. So that's just — everyone assumes that. It's all the other stuff that makes or breaks you.

MR: Oh that's a great statement. It's like being in the NBA. There's no bad basketball players.

JF: Yeah, right.

MR: And I can imagine learning to like keep inside yourself certain things you want to say. Like if you're dealing with an ad exec or something that just thinks they know how to talk about music and they say stupid things and you want to like correct them.

JF: Yeah. You can't overstep that kind of stuff. But yet you need to be personable and make a good impression.

MR: Do you have trouble keeping track, with all the things you do, of money that's owed to you?

JF: Money that's owed to me. No, not really. I'm pretty litigious about all that stuff. And I mean aside from when I first moved to New York there were a couple of shady folks who I never got the money from but you get to a point where you just kind of say okay that's gone, I'm not going to work for that guy again and I don't want to blow this up into a thing and have it bite me later. But no, you keep a calendar. They tell you what it pays, you write it in your calendar or put it in your computer and you have all the records of that. So I've never really had a problem. And because being a freelance musician is somewhat hand to mouth, you're waiting for it many times.

MR: Yeah if you look at your income over the year you probably have peaks and valleys.

JF: Of course, yeah. And it's totally unpredictable. I mean there's always a peak in like March, April, May — because I do a lot of work at schools, big concerts and stuff like that. But sometimes there's a giant peak in the middle of the year or toward the end of the

year where I do a tour with somebody or just happen to get a string of really nice things all in a row. So I think if I mapped out every year they'd all have a different look to them.

MR: How often do you have to — or do you — you have one thing on some date and someone offers you ten days and that thing is right in the middle of it. Do you ever have to call someone and say look I told you I was going to do this thing but now I've got this opportunity —

JF: I've had a couple of times. One time was a long time ago I had a concert at a very small college and it was just that, it was in the middle of something. I got offered like a 10-day tour or something, that paid a lot of money. And so I called up the school and it was well in advance. I called up the school and I said, "look, I have this opportunity. I'd like to do it. Here are some people I would highly recommend. They're all trombone players. They all do what I do. They write, and they would fit right in. They could even probably play the music you've been rehearsing of mine. They know my music and they're well enough known." This was a long time ago. I wasn't very well known. And so I worked out all the details for them. And I said, "look if there's a problem with the fee I'll make up the difference." Whatever. And then I took the other gig. And then the other one was one that I had a very nice gig at a school in Europe. It was like a week-long residency with a concert at the end. And it was going to be a lot of work but I was looking forward to it, because it was a very prestigious program. But then I got called — this is like three or four months before I was going to get married. And I got an opportunity for something in town that lasted like three months. And I felt bad enough leaving town for like twelve days or something with my wife trying to plan the wedding and everything. And at the same time we're buying a house and moving and all that stuff. So I told — this was three months before their event I contacted the school and I said I have this opportunity here and I'm going to have to decline your offer. There were no formal contracts or anything. And they were a little upset about it, even though they had plenty of time and they did find someone to cover what it was I was going to do, and he did a great job and they were very happy. But there was a little bit of animosity there which I feel bad about, because I was very excited about doing it. But at the same time — and it turned out the opportunity I stuck around in New York for, it was like a revue. It was on Broadway but it wasn't really a Broadway show, it was music, a music kind of revue, with a big band on stage and everything. And it paid New York Broadway scale so it paid pretty well. But it didn't run as long as it was going to run. So I made about as much as I would have made doing the other gig and probably would have had more fun doing the other gig, but at the time it just felt like come on, you're getting married, you're buying a house, you're moving, let's be a responsible adult here and not just leave town for two weeks and leave your wife holding the bag. But those were the only two times I've ever had to deal with that.

MR: Yeah. Has it been your experience, with all the musician friends you have, is it a hard life to have long lasting relationships?

JF: I think it depends on the person and it depends on your vision for what your career is going to be. I think if you're a stone cold artist and you don't want to make any compromises with what your artistic goal is, regardless of what's necessary to keep your relationship alive or your marriage together, or whatever, then it's going to take its toll. Because, you know, not every spouse understands the life of a musician or the thoughts why would you do this when you can make money here and you're doing that and you're not making money. It's common sense. So there is a give and take. With that being said, this is my second marriage now and my first wife was a musician. And my wife now is a trombone player. Bass trombone player actually. And I think I hit the jackpot with her. But it's nice because she understands the trials and tribulations of being a professional freelance artist. But it is tough. I know a lot of people that have gone through tough times and/or had to give up a little of their dream to be responsible adults and take care of their wife and family and maybe raise their level of how they live. Their lifestyle might — their family might not be worthy of living in a shoebox with roaches and rats. You know? So you play the gigs that pay the money that put you in the right position to be able to take care of your family. And that's the responsible thing to do. And some people are fine with that, and some people harbor some animosity because they've had to give up some of those things, and then that takes it toll on a marriage. So it's a tricky little balancing game. To be honest, I'm just as happy sitting at home and being with my wife and my dogs as I am playing a gig. So it's not anything that's rubbing me the wrong way.

MR: All right. I'm going to play a couple of things here. This is from one of, I guess you could call it one of your contemporaries.

[audio interlude]

JF: Unmistakable within the first couple of measures, that was Bill Watrous.

MR: Okay. Tell me why?

JF: First of all I appreciate you considering me one of his contemporaries, but Bill's like 20 years older than me and has had a glorious career.

MR: It's still alive, which is great.

JF: Yeah. And I've had some wonderful opportunities to hang out with him and play music with him and talk with him on the phone and he was very supportive of me early on. During my days with Woody Herman I know I still have a copy of it — there was an interview with him — Leonard Feather did an interview with him in the *L.A. Times* and when Leonard Feather asked him about new people coming up and he mentioned me and my writing and all that. And I was in New York and someone sent me the article and I saw it and I said wow this is amazing. So I wrote him a letter, not thinking anything, I

just wrote him a letter, "thank you so much you've been a big influence over the years." And he called me up. Out of the blue. Like shocking. I'd never met him before. So a really good guy and unbelievable technique. And when I was in high school was when his first big band records were coming out. And it was super-inspirational. Because kind of like Woody Herman with all the young guys, his group was kind of doing more like modern kind of Latin music and contemporary rock and things like that that were not really done with a lot of the older big bands. And of course all featuring trombone. How could I not like that? So he was one of my early influences in high school. My first one was Urbie Green but Bill definitely — that first big band album I got of his, the Wildlife — Manhattan Wildlife Refuge — when he does his crazy cadenza on this one tune that, how does anybody have that much technique. Unbelievable.

MR: Yeah. I remember watching in college a rare video, well before, you know YouTube wasn't thought of, but just watching this guy play with the Prince Valiant haircut and like.

JF: Yeah. Seemingly completely effortless when he plays. And it really knocked me out. And so I was really getting into him and Urbie. And someone said, "well you know Bill Watrous's influence is is Carl Fontana." So I said, "oh, who's Carl Fontana?" And at the time Carl had no albums out under his own name. He didn't record any albums under his own name until like 1986 or something like that. So I had to hunt for him. The first album I found was "SuperSax," that SuperSax album that he's featured on four or five tunes. Then he did a co-led album "Live at the Concord Jazz Festival," Hanna-Fontana Band with Jake Hanna. So technically I guess he led that group. But I wore those albums out. Because I realized okay Bill was on some here. This is the source. And the one thing I knew early on was I didn't want to sound exactly like anybody. So I thought okay, let's do what Bill did. We'll go back and listen to Carl and we'll see how that affects what I do through what I've been studying with Urbie, and obviously I discovered J.J. by that time, and Curtis Fuller and all these people. And Carl's — the first thing that struck me was the way he played time. His eighth note feel, how relaxed everything was, that really took to me immediately. And that's really what I wanted to go for there. So I kind of put him up on a pedestal for quite a long time, really trying to get close to his way of phrasing. Not the way he played notes, I mean I played similar things that he played, but I wasn't about like transcribing everything he did and playing it note for note. I wanted to just kind of get a sense for what his approach was and as far as inflections and time feel and all that stuff.

MR: Great. Here's a guy who's I think somewhat younger than you.

[audio interlude]

JF: Wycliffe [Gordon]? Yeah. That one spot and you could tell it's him. Yeah he's another guy with just a freaky set of chops. I mean technically he can go anywhere. And a lot of energy and a lot of air. Yeah. I've been working with him over the last six years now I guess. Every year in January I do this thing called the Jazz Cruise, which is an entire giant cruise ship dedicated entirely to jazz. No other entertainment on the boat. No Broadway shows, no silly whatever — someone making balloon animals. It's all jazz and they bring out all these great players. And I first did it in 2009 and they used to always bring a big band on in addition to all these collections of guys playing in small groups all over the ship. And then in 2009 they decided let's try putting all these guys together for the big band, to have like an all-star big band. And I was just a sideman at the time. Ken Peplowski, a clarinet player, was leading the band. And after that year he invited me back and he said, "you know what? Bring some charts. And this was getting to be a little too much for me." Because he was doing everything. He was setting up all the entertainment, he was playing, he was running the big band. He said, "let's split off — you take a couple of nights and I'll take a couple of nights." And then after we did that year he said, "you know what? It's yours. I'd rather just play." And so I've been leading that band since then. And the first couple of years Wycliffe did it. But he's always on the ship. But he's not always in the big band. But what a fantastic talent. Really great guy too.

MR: Uh huh. Does your wife get to go on the cruise?

JF: Believe it or not, she plays in the band as well.

MR: Oh, right.

JF: When Ken hired me to do the band, it was supposed to be me and Wycliffe and Andy Martin and John Allred. That was going to be the trombone section. And Andy Martin got some kind of movie date and had to cancel. And Ken said, "I need to get a fourth trombone player." And I said, "well you probably should get a bass trombone player." I said, "you know all the guys in New York," to get the top guys. "But just so you know, in case you don't have someone, my plus one is my wife and she's a great bass trombone player and she plays with this guy and this guy and this group and that group, and she plays really well. So if you get hung up." He goes, "no let's just do that." So he hired her and then she came on the boat and everybody loved her and she did a bang-up job and actually she got hired back for the next year before I did. So she plays with a lot of great groups in Manhattan. She's fantastic. Her name is Jennifer Wharton.

MR: Worton?

JF: Wharton. W-H-A-R-T-O-N.

MR: You used a term just now that I don't think I've heard: plus one. I mean instead of having three trombones you have four? Is that what you mean?

JF: I was talking about my guest on the ship. You are invited on the ship and you are allowed to bring a guest. So she was my plus one.

MR: Your plus one. Nice.

JF: You know how people put it on the guest list? John Fedchock plus one.

MR: Yeah. I'd like to be a plus one. Okay. Here's one last selection.

[audio interlude]

JF: That's me.

MR: Yes. And do you like it.

JF: You know it's interesting because I remember when I was on Woody's band, there were some other guys from Eastman that came out after I had joined the band. And they had some recordings of Eastman's band. And I was sitting, you know we're all riding in the bus and as most people did at that time you had headphones on and you'd be listening to music. And I remember I was listening and then I heard like somebody playing something else without headphones and it was like a trombone solo and it sounded interesting. I took my headphones off and went, "wow, that's me." So I guess I liked it. Sometimes I like hearing myself, sometimes I really don't. It's just like listening to your own voice on the answering machine. It never sounds quite like you expect it to sound.

MR: I want to come back to that thought regarding your band too. But —

[audio interlude]

That's pretty complex. And I wonder if you can tell me what you're thinking about when you improvise.

JF: First and foremost I'm thinking about the line — the melody that I'm playing. That it's informed by the harmony, but it also has the direction that the harmony wants it to go. The voice leading in the line, the direction of the resolution of the chords, it all makes sense within that. You know? So if I'm playing a line and I cross into a bar line it's almost like you can hear the key signature change when you cross into that new chord. And it's usually by some relationship of a half-step or some kind of resolving note like a seventh resolving into a third, or a third resolving to a seventh, or a sharp nine resolving into a thirteen, or something — like from the different stratas of resolution. So I'm trying to keep that in mind but at the same time I want to create a line that if I create tension in the line somewhere I always want to make sure that that tension is somewhere along the line readdressed and released. And that it's not necessarily a completely cognizant thing at this point in the way I play. It's something that I just hear and I know it's gotta go a certain way. And there may be two or three steps in between here and here. But eventually it ends up — you know like I'll play some kind of note that sticks out and then I go down here, I'm not going to leave it hanging. I'll eventually go back up and pick it up and move back in. That's just kind of — regardless of how much I alter the harmony

or what kind of chord substitutions I use, I'm always trying to think about these tension notes. They're there for a reason. You know just to play tension notes just for the sake of tension, the great thing about music is tension and release. So they all serve a purpose. Like that seventh — there's a strong pull to go to the third, on a five-one relationship. So the same thing goes for a lot with the upper extensions. I feel there's a very strong resolution to a lot of these things. So even if I'm not consciously thinking of it, now I'm to the point where I'm subconsciously remembering that note and coming back up to take care of whatever I left hanging.

MR: I really like that. And you sort of, I think, answered my next question, was about wrong notes in improvising. I think you sort of just addressed it already.

JF: Sure. I mean there are certain notes that sound better than others but to be honest any note can be played over any chord if it's approached from the right note and leads to the right note.

MR: So if you don't, does it constitute — you know this term "wrong note" I know is debatable. But if you were teaching a lesson and someone's playing a note that really doesn't quite belong and they're not either justifying it or setting it up. Would you say to that student, "that could be done better," or something?

JF: Oh of course, yes. And I would say it's not a wrong note but it's a wrong way to play that note over that chord. You know there's a certain way to get to that note. If you're going to just go for it and have it sound really wrong, which a lot of great players have done, you've got to have some way to skillfully tell everybody you meant to do that and it wasn't a mistake. And you have to have the presence of mind, you have to be able to do that, and you have to be relaxed not to do that, and you have to be comfortable in your own skin enough. You know it's like using the wrong word in a sentence. Some people might completely freeze up if they had the camera on them or in public speaking. You know, it's the same type of thing. But if you know the word's wrong and you kind of just correct yourself and move on it's fine. Everyone understands what you were trying to say and it's fine. Or to the extreme, look at someone like Norm Crosby. He knew exactly what he was talking about — I don't know if you're familiar with him, he's a comedian. He was the king of the malapropisms. He would use the wrong word but you would still know what he was talking about. And it was funny because you knew it was the wrong word but you knew what he was talking about.

MR: When I listen to some, any number of people, I think of Dizzy Gillespie sometimes. And sometimes he plays something and I go my God, I never would have thought of that. And it's until you maybe listen to it again, it didn't sound right.

JF: Yeah. But what's interesting with Dizzy, when you hear him play there is so much forethought in what he did. When he does those notes you can hear the intent. It's not an

accident. And then there's someone like Miles Davis, who in my mind I think he would intentionally play wrong notes to get his rhythm section to creatively find a way to make something happen. And that's the thing. If you're going to play those notes from out of the key or however you want to describe it, you need to have a sensitive rhythm section. If you have someone just banging out the chords — one-three-five-seven-nine — like this, and you play this stuff and they don't follow you, it's going to sound wrong, no matter how your intent is. So it's got to be a give and take and that communication within the rhythm section too. The people that are accompanying you, if they don't have the facility — like I've played with many groups — pick up groups — where you can just tell the piano player is not going to go there. No matter what you do. And sure you can do it, and you can feel good, okay this is my thing, I'm going to do my thing, but musically it doesn't make sense. You know it's like sitting in a room with three garbage men and trying to talk quantum physics. You know, you're not going to have a good conversation. You may be a hundred percent right, but what's it doing for the conversation? Nothing. So in those cases I just reel it back and I say okay well I'm just going to play more straight-ahead and enjoy being in that box tonight.

MR: Um hum. And that is a challenge in itself.

JF: Yeah. Yeah. And I learned a lot about doing that working with student groups. Because they don't have a lot of facility. So you've got to be able to create interesting solos and something that feels different and fresh based upon very basic information that they're supplying you as an accompaniment.

MR: Well said. When I was at Fredonia, this was late 60s, early 70s, we used to put on Blood, Sweat & Tears and Chicago, and for our age group at that time, like oh man, I want to do that.

JF: Sure.

MR: Did you ever have that — did you have a band or a — for you was it more the big bands?

JF: That was my first inspiration, although I did listen to groups like that. I had Chicago records and Blood, Sweat & Tears records and things like that, and I got to work with Blood, Sweat & Tears when I moved to New York, a few times. But it was more the straight-ahead jazz that inspired me. And I'm not sure why that was but it was. I mean I liked all the more modern stuff. I listened to the Maynard Ferguson albums in the 70s when he was doing all the rock stuff and it was — a lot of that stuff was very interesting to me and I thought it was great. But I think it was because I wanted to be an improviser and all the great improvisers played over straight-ahead music. All the people I wanted to sound like played over straight-ahead music at the time. So I just got more and more into that. And I realized that there was more and more to that. I mean obviously Blood, Sweat

& Tears had a lot of great jazz harmony, as did Chicago. But as far as the soloists go, they weren't unleashed as much as they were in jazz.

MR: Right. It's a shame sometimes when you hear Blood, Sweat & Tears on like the oldies station or whatever, they always snip out those middle parts with the —

JF: The extended, yeah. It's sad to hear.

MR: You strike me as a fairly even-keeled guy. I wonder if there's anything that really gets on your nerves musically.

JF: I'm not one for showboating or one-upmanship on the bandstand, you know, people that play for sport, that it's more like a competition than a sharing kind of a thing. My favorite players are the guys that, even on like instruments — my favorite trombone players to play with are the guys where you play something and the other guy doesn't feel obligated to play it back better or higher or faster. And there are a lot of cases of people doing that, where you don't really feel like you're making music together, it's just like — for lack of a better term, excuse my French, but a pissing contest, you know? And I get to the point where that really turns me off. And I actually just kind of revert to staying out of the game. So you've got one guy who's all over the place, and one guy just okay let's calm down here. And it doesn't make for a good program, but I can't live in that room. That's kind of not my personality. I found out a long time ago that's not my personality. So that's the only thing. It doesn't make me mad, it's just disappointing because you want to make music and you get in those situations and it's like oh — and that is the mentality in a lot of those festival type atmospheres. They want to hear everybody pitted against everybody and the battle of the bones, or things like — you know, but it's much more fun to me when it's just like playing music. You do your thing, I do my thing and let's just kind of make it work like you would if you were talking to somebody.

MR: Have you ever done any of the jazz parties?

JF: Yeah I've done some of those, sure. Yeah. Those are fun.

MR: They are. And they don't usually descend into that.

JF: Right. Exactly. And that's what — the jazz cruise is like that as well. Everybody's just kind of like having a great time and nobody's got an agenda.

MR: Right. Leave your agenda at the —

JF: At the doorstep. Yeah right.

MR: Yeah we got to go on one of those things. I thought I was in heaven. I didn't know such a thing existed. You know here's Joe Williams and Oscar Peterson and Nat Adderley.

JF: Yeah. And it's great for the musicians too, because it's rare that we have more than just time to say hello, how's it going, what's been going on. Actually when I'm on the ship, you know, you can have long, you know, fairly meaningful conversations with these guys that you haven't really had a chance to say much other than how's the weather.

MR: Yeah. And you don't have to talk about music all the time. Because you get a little bit more time.

JF: Yeah.

MR: If you could increase one of the things that you do right now — you're also doing some producing. Would you increase one more thing as opposed to something else?

JF: Well my first love was always playing, so I guess it would be playing. You know it's hard when I'm writing I usually have to let the playing take a back seat and I don't practice as much and I occasionally won't take gigs because if I'm trying to finish a project or whatever. And I kind of miss it. So I miss writing less. If I'm playing a bunch and I'm not writing I don't miss not writing. I don't miss writing. But if I'm not playing I really miss it. And it actually affects me psychologically too. I get fidgety, I'm not relaxed, I'm just not as happy a person.

MR: If you get a call to do a commission, are there guidelines that you like to get. For instance, if someone says I have a big band, write something for me, that's very wide open.

JF: Yeah.

MR: Is it harder to do it that way than to say you know I really could use a Latin chart and we have a strong trumpet section?

JF: Yeah I don't want to say it's harder. I would say there's a higher chance — a greater chance that what I do may not fit this person's group. If they say we don't care, just write something, and they give me no limitations, I'm going to write for my own band and then give them the chart. They'll pay me for it, and then I'll play it with my group and record it. You know? So I usually require guidelines. Because I want everyone to be happy and I want the word of mouth to be that we asked him to write something, it came out great and it was perfect for our group. You know? So I usually ask about the talent in the group and the limitations and who the soloists are, what stylistically the band can handle, things like that. And so far I've hit the mark on all of them, but occasionally you'll get a director who maybe has a loftier impression of what his group is, and maybe bites off a little more than he can chew for his group, you know, saying that they could do something when they're really not prepared to do that. But I always kind of take things with a grain of salt, depending on how confident the director sounds when he's saying all these things. But in general the ultimate goal is that I write something for them that they're happy with and that I also get to play it with my group. It kills two birds with one stone.

MR: And how do you decide on what to charge?

JF: I have a kind of a standard fee and then I tell the group look — especially if it's a group that's a professional or a highly touted university group, if it's something that I really don't have a lot of limitations to then I'll work with you. If you can't afford my price, let

me know what you can afford and maybe we can meet in the middle or something like that. Or if you wouldn't mind — you know some places ask you to write them a chart and then tell me it's got to be an exclusive, like I can't play it with my group, I can't have it published, like they want an exclusive for their group because they're paying all this money. And I understand completely. So with that I set my price a little differently and things like that.

MR: I would think so, yeah. Well just to wrap up here, every year there's thousands of graduates of jazz schools coming into the market. What's your outlook for them?

JF: Depends where you go I guess. It seems — I think in another ten years we're going to really find out what happens with all this. Because for the past 15 years all these jazz programs have been supplying new teachers for the jazz programs. So you've got a lot of really, really good teachers in jazz programs now. Much more accomplished than the old days. You've got a lot of great jazz programs everywhere. But then the question is where does everybody else go now that all these jobs are filled. There's no more road bands so the answer is a lot of people are getting into one of the military bands or doing cruise ship work, things like that. You can't even move to a place like Las Vegas anymore and make a living very well. So it's a very different thing. New York is probably one of the few places where anybody that's got anything together can move to New York and eke out a living, because there's so many different things going on. You've got Broadway, you've got live work, you've got a club date scene which is playing weddings and things like that. In New York it's like beyond professional level. You know, these giant weddings and they play with these 10-piece groups that are slick and polished with giant sound systems and all that stuff. That's a big, big industry in New York. And there's just a lot of live venues and live gigs and there's orchestras and symphonies and the opera and all that stuff. There's plenty of little places where guys can kind of combine all this stuff to make a living doing this and that and this and that. Los Angeles I think is a little more smaller scope. It's got the studio scene and a little bit of live work that maybe tours, but it's mostly commercial music for the most part and not a lot of jazz clubs out there. So it's kind of not as multi-faceted as New York. So we'll see, we'll see. But I think, I tell students all the time, I mean what do you say to these students that want to be musicians? I say well if they're like me there's no choice. I had to be a musician. There was nothing else I wanted to do. I would have been miserable being anything else. So you've got to take your shot. And if you apply yourself and do all the right things you're going to make a success of yourself. And if you don't then it's on you. And so I think there's still room for people. The Broadway scene in New York is very healthy right now. There's a lot of musicians making really good livings. And you know, music's everywhere and you may have to modify your standard of living a little bit when you first move to a city and a lot

of students are not comfortable with that concept. But yeah, we'll see. We'll see how this all — now that all the teaching jobs are filled, we'll see what happens with the rest of the crew.

MR: Well said. I really enjoyed talking to you today.

JF: Likewise, Monk, thank you.

MR: Okay. Thank you.